

access to the public. Thieves target isolated temples, where there are many antique idols," says Inspector Kader Batcha of the Idol Wing.

Although nearly 50 per cent of art work found in foreign auction houses is believed to be stolen, the Indian government rarely stakes a claim to its antiquities because it has knowledge and documentation of only a small fraction of its monuments and antiquities. Without records proving an auction item belongs to India, the Government can't claim the item. Cases such as the return of the Siva Nataraja are rare. In 1976, the government rallied to bring

provenance, past sales, literature, exhibitions and acquisition dates for greater transparency," says Christie's Vice-President and India representative Menaka Kumari Shah. But Director of the Indian Council on Cultural Relations Neeru Misra says the history of an item is sometimes lost by the time it arrives at an auction house as it has already exchanged many hands. "Many auction houses hide the fact that unlike a museum, they don't have to provide the antecedents of the object, that is where it comes from. Almost 50 per cent of art at auction houses is stolen," she says.

protected monuments are disappearing due to urbanisation and nowhere is this more apparent than the national capital where 17 such monuments have simply disappeared. This include the 19th century Pool Chadar, a 162-ft-wide aqueduct that carried surplus water and the site of the siege battery dating back to the 1857 struggle. Narayanasamy recently revealed in Parliament that 35 monuments have vanished across the nation. Private collectors are also selling off valuable antiquities such as Rajasthani miniatures and coins. Some collectors are one-time aristocrats who are desper-

ately trying to make a living by selling their family treasures.

Under the Antiquities Act, any item sold without registration with the government is illegal. Osian's Chairman Neville Tuli says this "ambiguous and archaic" legislation is part of the problem. "If there was an open, transparent market in India, 95 per cent of the smuggling problem would disappear as smugglers will legally make more money in a transparent trade within their country," Tuli adds.

The art community agrees that not only do laws need to be implemented strictly, but secu-

rity of temples needs to be stepped up too. Experts say India's lack of value for its own heritage underlies the whole problem. "The knowledge, concern and love for heritage needs to be nurtured. People are ignorant and don't have a sense of pride in our heritage. Power and money are the only strength," says Misra. While the nation clamoured to ensure the return of the Siva Nataraja, perhaps the same national sentiment is required to save thousands of heritage items that are silently disappearing every day. ■

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THE TWO ACCUSED IN THE EMERALD LINGAM THEFT (LEFT); IDOL SMUGGLING KINGPIN ASOKAN

home the stolen Nataraja, which had been bought for \$900,000 by US collector Simon Norton from a dealer. The Nataraja was brought home nearly a decade later. "For every Siva Nataraja that is returned, there are thousands that are disappearing," says Galla.

Auction houses insist they have rigorous checks in place to ensure they do not auction stolen items. "We require our consignors to confirm the legitimacy of their title to objects and encourage our clients to allow us to publish the fullest information about

The Antiquities Act of 1972 is designed to regulate the export of cultural objects and prevent smuggling. ASI's Joint Director-General B.R. Mani says the Act has helped curtail smuggling. "If an item has come from India, it can't be sold at a foreign auction house and must be returned. The problem arises from the fact that art from Bangladesh, Pakistan and India look the same," he says. But Misra says the Act is rarely implemented and the culprits rarely brought to book.

Meanwhile, the government-